

Ten Steps to Community Development

For the purposes of this course, the general community development process can be synthesized into the following basic steps. However, community development is an organic process, so that the "*steps*" are presented in a logical order, in reality they may not follow sequentially and some steps may either be skipped or carried out simultaneously with other steps.

1. Learn About the Community

Whether you want to be an active member of the community, an effective service provider or a community leader, you will have to be familiar with its issues, resources, needs, power structure and decision-making processes. Your initial orientation includes reading your local newspaper regularly, attending community events, reading reports and familiarizing with available services as well as community projects and activities. Close observation of the community as you interact with it will also provide significant insights into the strengths and weaknesses of the community.

2. Listen to Community Members

You won't be able to learn everything you need to know by reading and observation. You will need to talk to others about their interests and perceptions to put it into context. You can contact community members through formal channels, such as joining a local organization or informally by chatting with people that visit the library and that you can encounter in other situations, such as shopping at local stores or attending school activities. By listening to the community, you may identify an area in which they have a common interest in making a change.

Health organization staff needs to maintain regular contact with the community to collect enough information to make sound recommendations and decisions on health services and priorities and to identify important community issues.

3. Bring People Together to Develop a Shared Vision

Once you have identified that there are some common interests among community members and you have identified a few individuals who seem willing to work on a community development initiative, the next step is to hold a community gathering. In some circumstances, it may be appropriate to invite representatives of specific organizations or sector to attend but more often it would be a public event for all the identified members. The purpose of this gathering would be to develop a shared "**community vision**"; i.e. through imagining their ideal community and discussing their ideas together they will determine or arrive at a common vision and some broad strategic directions/ strategies on which all are committed to work. You may also use this gathering to ask for support for such initiative, elicit (*evoke, induce, obtain*) community input or invite members to join a ***steering committee** or help in other ways.

***Steering committee**, an advisory *committee* usually made up of high level stakeholders and/or experts who provide guidance on key issues such as company policy and objectives, budgetary control, marketing strategy, resource allocation, and decisions involving large expenditures

4. Assess Community Assets and Resources, Needs and Issues

To be able to work effectively in a community development context, you will need to gather some information about your community. It is extremely helpful to undertake (*manage, tackle, assume, deal with*) a comprehensive community assessment which will collect both **qualitative** and **quantitative** data on a wide range of community features. Unfortunately, often time and budget restraints (*control*) compel or necessitate you to choose the methods and limit the assessment on particular areas of interest.

There are many methods of community assessment used in community development practice. A few of the more common methods are listed below;

Compiling a community demographic profile is an excellent start. It is helpful to update the profile periodically so you will be able to track changes that occur within your community and respond accordingly. A demographic profile includes statistical information about age, gender, language, visible minority status, education and family income. Other community statistics may also be of interest to you, such as crime rates, morbidity (r silent) and mortality rates or availability of affordable housing and such data may be obtained from local agencies; e.g. the local police service will have crime statistics.

However, simply collecting information is not sufficient; it must be analyzed in order to be meaningful. **For example**, you might be interested in the relative proportion of seniors to youth in your community, or the proportion of the population for whom English is a second language. You may want to compare the most recent data available with previous years; perhaps to identify the rate of growth of the population, changes in ethno-cultural patterns.

Statistical information isn't the only type of information that is important to collect. Finding out how residents perceive their community is also essential to effective community development practice. Community surveys, community asset mapping, environmental scans, focus groups and key informant interviews are other methods of obtaining community data.

5. Help Community Members to Recognize and Articulate Areas of Concern and their Causes.

In any community development process, it is the community that is in the **driver's seat**. Community members will define the issues and the process for resolving them, which might be quite different than what would be proposed by "**an external expert**". However, it is the community members that are most familiar with the situation and in many cases, have knowledge and wisdom that an external expert lacks. By providing tools, resources, meetings and facilitation, community developers empower the community to start to take ownership of the issues and the development of solutions.

**If we genuinely want to empower [communities], we must do it in such a way that they become independent and self reliant, that they can sustain (keep alive) their own development without our help.*

6. Establish an 'Vehicle of Change'

In most circumstances it will be necessary to create an ***organizational change**, which in most cases will start as a steering committee. Depending on the circumstances, nature of the group could range from a few unaffiliated individuals or a coalition (*joining together of different parties or groups for a particular purpose, usually for a limited time*) of organizations and institutions. There is a wide range of activities that the steering committee will need to undertake to ensure that it will be able to plan, organize, implement and evaluate the initiative effectively, including developing a ***charter** or terms of reference, establishing ***governance policies**, obtaining sufficient resources to carry out the work and identifying potential partners who can contribute to its success.

***organizational change** is a process in which a large company or organization changes its working methods or aims, for example in order to develop and deal with new situations or markets

***charter** is a formal statement of the rights of a country's people, or of an organization or a particular social group, that is agreed by or demanded from a ruler or government

***policy governance** defines and guides appropriate relationships between an organization's owners, its Board of directors and chief executive

7. Develop an Action Plan

Assuming that the community as a whole has set the strategic directions for the initiative, the steering committee will now develop the action plan. In addition, if there are a number of activities or events to plan, you will need a separate action plan for each one. The point you need to arrive at, is a well developed plan that clearly links activities with objectives and indicates responsibilities, time frames and required resources.

8. Implement Action Plan

This is the **heart of the initiative** (*process to achieve something*), in which financial and human resources, including volunteers and community members are mobilized (*to organize or prepare something, such as a group of people, for a purpose*) to take action. Perhaps the community has decided to establish a ***coalition against homelessness**, the actions might consist of:

- Working with community workers to identify needs and appropriate services;
- Developing informational brochures;
- Eliciting (*to get/obtain*) support from targeted organizations;
- Distributing the brochures to the organizations; and
- Meeting with organizational representatives to provide further information.

In addition, to implementing the various action steps, it is important to ensure that the factors, which are required for the success of any community are in place, such as:

- Shared vision and purpose
- Concrete, attainable goals and objectives
- Sufficient funds, staff, materials and time
- Skilled, participatory leadership
- Clear roles and policy guidelines
- Mutual respect
- Open communications, including both formal and informal methods
- Recognition that there are ***process people** and there are **action people**; ensure there is a variety of ways of participating in or contributing to the initiative
- Time and resources management; don't take on more than you can handle at one time; set priorities
- Conflict management; don't let problems slide - address them in an open, honest and timely manner
- Good record-keeping; e.g. financial reports, meeting minutes
- Fun; don't forget to celebrate your successes - even small ones!

*The goal is to unite different parties, such as local government agencies, non-profits, businesses, and volunteers, to tackle homelessness through a collaborative and organized approach.

* In a project setting, a **process person** might want to carefully outline the entire project plan, detailing each step, timeline, and potential risks before starting. An **action person** might prefer to start the project right away, handling issues as they arise, and adjusting the plan dynamically as they go along.

9. Evaluate Results of Actions

Traditionally, community development workers have relied more on their own experience, rather than formal evaluation procedures. Often it is difficult to find reasonable and appropriate measures in terms of the cost and time. However, there are many reasons why it is important to evaluate your work. (i) Most importantly, you may need to demonstrate that you have not caused any harm to others through your actions. (ii) to demonstrate the effectiveness of the initiative (*plan, project*) so that it will be continued, (iii) to satisfy funder requirements and (iv) to provide information that will be useful to others or to subsequent (*successive*) initiatives.

Evaluation plans may be formal or informal and tailored (*modify, amend, revise*) to the needs and resources of the group. In community development, a participatory evaluation method is usually conducted in place of more traditional method. Participatory evaluation program involves participants or community members in the evaluation design, data collection, and the analysis and interpretation of results.

10. Reflect and Regroup

Allow time for the group to catch its breath before embarking (*begin, start*) on the next initiative. Thank everyone that contributed and make sure to develop good follow up communication with media, partner and funders. Celebrate your successes and reflect on (*review, consider*)

any disappointments that might have occurred. Discuss that how well the organizational processes and structures worked and identify areas that need some attention before the next rush of activity occurs. Also, it is important to provide a space for participants to reflect on their personal development as a result of being part of the group. When the group is ready to tackle a new initiative, then they might want to revisit the strategic directions and decide whether those steps need to be repeated.
